

School for SQUABBLES

The prime minister wants world class universities but the implementing agencies can't agree on how to do it

| By Shafi Rahman |

When Prime Minister Manmohan Singh placed before the nation the idea of setting up 14 universities with exceptional academic qualities, the move was aimed at accelerating the knowledge economy. The academic-turned prime minister chose to call them 'World Class Universities', sexing up the come-get-me factor. "These universities should focus on international standards of excellence and be rated among the top institutions in the world. They must become the launching pads for our entry into the knowledge economy," Manmohan said at a function held to celebrate 150 years of the University of Mumbai in June 2007.

Now, it seems not all ears are attuned to his voice. The infuriating turn of events, in which the Human Resource Ministry, the National Knowledge Commission (NKC) and the University Grants Commission (UGC) are taking on each other, have left the UPA Government dithering in taking the final call on its master plan. The chances of missing the February deadline to pass the bill in the short session of Parliament are high and the Government is looking at the possibility of pushing it through an ordinance.

The discussions to prepare a blueprint for World Class Universities started off with a complete sense of urgency. But with more stakeholders chipping in, opinions differed on how to reach the lofty heights. The tangle

started off with the UGC preparing a draft concept note for the World Class Universities in August last year without outlining a clear-cut plan on how to create them out of greenfield campuses. It kicked off intense grumblings, especially on the way these universities should be run. A fuming Knowledge Commission shot off a letter to UGC Chairman Sukhdeo Thorat suggesting to make the necessary changes—from the curriculum to the approach to trade unionism—as XI Plan provisions for these universities were made partly in pursuance of the recommendations of the NKC.

The UGC is of the view that the universities should be run by the government and wants to underplay the role of private players and corporates. The ministry on its part is ready to open it up to "credible private organisations" and offer them public land. The Knowledge Commission has a different take. "Since public finance is an integral constituent of universities worldwide, most of the new universities shall need significant initial financial support from the Government. Each university may be endowed with a substantial allocation of public land, in excess of its spatial requirements," says Sam Pitroda, chairman, NKC. The excess land can be a subsequent source of income generation, he says. Exceptions need to be made in existing income tax laws to encourage large endowments.

Though the NKC was set up with the best wishes of the prime minister, its toughest challenge had always come



Dissenting Notes ▶▶

The NKC wants to enhance both financial autonomy and accountability of the universities.

It seeks salary differentials for teachers between universities as well as between disciplines within universities.

from Manmohan's own backyard—the HRD Ministry. Headed by his *bête noire* Arjun Singh, it has shot down almost all the proposals of the NKC for reviving higher education. The latest tiff came last week when the ministry decided to take Central Universities Bill through the ordinance route to enable setting up of 12 new central universities against NKC's wishes.

This time, the ministry has found a compliant ally in the UGC. On the faculty front, the UGC is sticking to ideas which had sent almost all of our